

Seminar # 11:
LOVE, COURTSHIP, AND MARRIAGE

BIBLICAL PRINCIPLES OF LOVE, COURTSHIP AND MARRIAGE

I. LOVE

A. LOVE DEFINED

Love, according to the dictionary, is a strong affection for, attachment or devotion to a person.

1. LOVE IS...

- **truthful.** It rejoices in the truth (1Corinthians 13:6). Love delights to tell the truth. Lovers are not afraid to confide their weaknesses to their partners for their mutual benefit.
- **sustaining.** It bears all things (1Corinthians 13:7). True love does not collapse under strain, whether emotional, mental or physical.
- **trusting.** It believes all things (1Corinthians 13:7). True love thinks good motives; it is not suspicious.
- **hopeful.** It hopes all things (1Corinthians 13:7). True love always expects the best.
- **enduring.** It endures all things (1Corinthians 13:7). It endures through time, deception and even death.
- **successful.** Love never fails (1Corinthians 13:8).

2. LOVE IS NOT...

- **envious.** Love does not envy (1Corinthians 13:4). True love does not envy success, gifts, talents, and the possessions of others.
- **boastful.** Love is not proud (1Corinthians 13:4). It does not show off. It maintains humility.
- **conceited.** Love is not puffed up (1Corinthians 13:4). True love always prefers the other to one's self.
- **rude.** Love does not behave improperly (1Corinthians 13:4). It is never coarse or offensive. True love is courteous at all times.
- **selfish.** Love is not self-seeking (1Corinthians 13:5). Love sacrifices and gives generously.

- o **irritable.** Love is not easily provoked (1Corinthians 13:5). True love is not touchy.
- o **ensorious.** Love thinks no evil (1Corinthians 13:5). It is not critical, reproving, nagging, suspicious or blaming.
- o **sin-loving.** Love does not delight in evil (1Corinthians 13:6). True love hates, abhors and loathes sin.

3. **NOTIONS ABOUT LOVE**

- a. ***Love ought not to be based on feelings.***
- b. ***Love should not be rooted in physical attraction.*** (Judges 14:1-3)
- c. ***Love is not sexual attraction.*** Sex is beautiful. Nothing is dirty or ugly about it. However, it is not the test of love, neither should it be done outside the sanctity of marriage.
- d. ***Love is not blind; it is not irresistible.*** Character, ideals and spiritual qualities are essential for love to become enduring, lasting.

B. **ELEMENTS OF LOVE**

1. **Patience** – It takes time to get to know each other, to decide, to check your decision.
2. **Commitment** – There should be a covenant between God and both of you.
3. **Responsibility** – As Christians, you must be responsible for each other's well-being.
4. **Discipline** – True love requires self-control. (2Timothy 1:7)
5. **Sacrifice** – Love does not shrink from sacrifice. (John 3:16; Romans 5:8)
6. **Faithfulness** – (Hosea 3:1-3)

C. **KINDS OF LOVE (by Dick Mills)**

1. **EROS** – This is sexual love, physical love. It is the mutual desire between a man and a woman.
2. **ESTORGE** – This is the love one has for the family. (Romans 12:10)
3. **PHILEO** – This is the love of friendship. It is the affection we feel for other people in friendly relationship.
4. **AGAPE** – This is Divine Love. It is that constant, everlasting love that can be bestowed by God alone.

II. COURTSHIP

Courtship is the journey where the man seeks to ascertain the woman who will help him fulfill God's destiny and where the woman establishes the man who will be her partner for life. Both the man and the woman must determine the Lord's will. The woman's decision must be both fair and reasonable. If she says yes, her yes will stand for a lifetime.

A. GUIDANCE TO COURTSHIP (Genesis 24:1-67; 29:1-30)

1. Don't go out to date or court a Canaanite [unbeliever]. (Genesis 24:3,4)
2. Do not be equally yoked [form no love relationship] with an unbeliever. (2 Corinthians 6:14)
3. Be empowered, as a Christian, to give Agape Love [Divine Love].
4. Trust God. We can obtain God's guidance through
 - a. the Word of God – (Proverbs 3:5-6; 2Timothy 3:16)
 - b. prayer – (Philippians 4:6)
 - c. godly counsel – (Proverbs 11:14; Proverbs 15:22)
 - d. circumstances – (Romans 8:28)
 - e. God's provision – (Philippians 4:19)
5. Possess the real beauty that comes from within. (Isaiah 53:2; Psalm 139:14)
6. Wait till you are assured (Genesis 24:21). Courtship takes time.

B. CARNAL AND DESTRUCTIVE METHODS OF CHOOSING A PARTNER

1. Choosing by sight (Genesis 6:2-5; Judges 14:1-3). We are not to choose only by what we see.
2. Fleshly choice motivated by lust and sin (2Samuel 11:1-5, 27; Genesis 34:1- 4). The flesh deceives.
3. Personal decision lacking divine approval. (Proverbs 3:5-6)
4. Praying and asking God to do what His Word already forbids. (Deuteronomy 7:1-4; Joshua 23:11-13; 2 Corinthians 6:15-18; Luke 16:18; Romans 7:2-3)

III. MARRIAGE

Marriage is meant to be happy as it is the residue of sinless Eden (Genesis 1:28). "He who finds a wife finds what is good and receives favor from the Lord." (Proverbs 18:22)

A. REASONS FOR MARRIAGE

1. It is divinely ordained. It is God's plan, purpose and provision from the beginning. (Genesis 2:18, 20, 22, 24; Psalm 68:6; Matthew 19:4-5; Ephesians 5:23, 31)
2. It is instrumental to completeness and fulfillment of true living. (Ephesians 5:23; 29-31)

Marriage provides needed fellowship, comfort, companionship, and partnership. With very few exceptions, we should marry. The few exceptions should be guided by God (Matthew 19:10-12; 1Corinthians 7:7-8, 32,34) and must not be the product of childish decision, misguided imitation, faithless conclusion or religious compulsion.

3. It must be a compliment to God's work of procreation (Genesis 1:27-28, 9:1; Psalm 128:3; Malachi 2:15; Ephesians 6:1-3). We are, in a sense, co-creators with God. We are to love our children in the same way God has loved His creation.

B. METHODS OF CONFIRMING GOD'S WILL

We may confirm God's will through:

1. **God's Word** (Psalm 119:105, 130; Matthew 22:29; 2Timothy 3:16-17)
2. **The voice of the Holy Spirit:** His prompting and directing in you (John 10:4-5,27, 14:26, 16:12-13; 1Corinthians 12:8; Romans 8:14; Proverbs 20:27)
3. **Direct revelation** (John 16:13; Joel 2:1-29)
4. **Testing.** God-given love cannot be quenched by temporal contrary circumstances. Instead, it overcomes trials and temptations (1 Corinthians 13:1-7; Ephesians 5:20-22).

C. WHEN TO MARRY

You may marry when...

1. God has guided you into the marriage after much prayer and after seeking His will.
2. you know the other person sufficiently well as to know his or her likes and dislikes, good points and bad points. Hasty marriages are dangerous.
3. you have waited for love. Marriage is for life and it will take God-like love to establish a happy home.
4. have waited until you are old enough to marry. Marriage carries heavy responsibilities requiring maturity and experience.
5. have waited until moral problems have been settled. Never marry a man to reform him. It is better to never marry a man whose habits can only mean bitterness and ruined marriage and unhappy home. Change should come before marriage.
6. you have waited until you have attained a certain measure of financial stability.

D. PRINCIPLES OF A HAPPY MARRIAGE

Your reactions to each other in three basic areas are the most important:

1. your expectations for the future
2. your pattern of communication
3. how the two of you will make decisions and settle disagreements
 - a. Know your expectations.
 - a.1. How do you want to be treated as a person?
 - a.2. What is your concept of how your mate wishes to be treated as a person?
 - a.3. What do you believe are your responsibilities and rights as a married person?
 - a.4. What do you perceive are the responsibilities and rights of your partner?
 - a.5. What do you expect from your marriage in the long run?
 - b. Express your feelings properly.
 - b.1. Speak without anger or hostility. Learn to develop a pleasant tone of voice.
 - b.2. Be clear and specific.
 - b.3. Be positive. This means no faultfinding, blaming, judging, name-calling, and other negative behavior. Be more appreciative.
 - b.4. Be courteous and respectful of your mate's opinion. You can do this even if you don't agree. Be as concerned for your mate's opinion as you are for your own.
 - b.5. Be sensitive to the needs and feelings of your mate. If your mate hurts, you can understand that hurt and even hurt, too. Tune in to feelings of anxiety and needs.
 - c. Become a better listener.
 - c.1. Show interest in your partner. Show that nothing else in the world matters except hearing your partner out. Maintain good eye contact, and respond with a smile or a nod of your head from time to time.
 - c.2. While listening, use appropriate phrases to show agreement, interest, and understanding. Show your partner that you understand the ideas presented.
 - c.3. Ask well-phrased questions. This shows interest and encourages the speaker.

- c.4. Listen a little longer. Just when you think you are through listening, listen 30 seconds longer.
- d. Reach decisions and settle disagreements.
 - d.1. Be willing to discuss any problem.
 - d.2. Try to resolve differences without making one person “right” and the other “wrong.”
 - d.3. Avoid angry outbursts. “Blowing your top” rarely produces positive results.
 - d.4. Determine the real issues involved.
 - d.5. Regardless of how much you disagree with your partner or how different your experience is, your mate’s viewpoint will have some positive angles. The decision may have been achieved through sound reasoning or from strictly emotional response, but you should not dismiss your mate’s perspective from your mind. You need not agree with it, but you should seek, with respect, to understand why your partner feels the way about the matter.
- e. Be well-founded. Make your foundation sure.
 - e.1. Make an absolute commitment to your marriage.
 - e.2. If serious trouble develops, seek help immediately.
 - e.3. Stay interested in each other. Date your mate.
 - e.4. Have Bible study and prayer everyday.
 - e.5. Love your mate as Christ loves the Church.
 - e.6. Follow 1 Corinthians 13.

Source: The Compleat Marriage By Nancy Van Pelt